

cusses on enhancing the employee experience by providing them with the right tools and systems. The third pillar is the emphasis on increased productivity,” explains Manian. Today, a customer builds trust in a company by way of experience. “We have to re-imagine what banking means for this new generation,” says Lathia, who is Chief of Customer Experience & Head of Technology of Consumer Bank. In fact, there were some subtle hints of the new KMB in Kotak’s messaging to shareholders in 2022-23: it talked about “change” in 2021-22 and promised “accelerating change” the very next year. The pace of “change”, which the bank is now targeting, has intensified post-Covid-19. “In the future, banks will essentially be tech companies offering banking products,” says Ekambaram. “What does it take to build a sustainable institution for the future? Product excellence, customer obsession, and trust. We, at Kotak, are in the midst of this mindset shift for these priorities,” Kotak had said in his address to shareholders this year.

As part of this, KMB has prioritised hiring top-tier global talent in technology, customer experience, mar-

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THE MAJOR INVESTMENTS ARE TAKING PLACE IN IT ARCHITECTURE, DATA ANALYTICS, AND TALENT

keting, branding, and data and risk analytics. That’s where Lathia, Nagnur as Chief Technology Officer, Bhasin as Head of Retail Liabilities Product and Chief Marketing Officer, and Kumar as Head of Retail and Commercial Risk fit in. They, in turn, handpicked their teams from hundreds of people from companies like Amazon, X, Ola, Microsoft, and more, adding to the bank’s workforce of 73,481. “Make Kotak a customer-centric bank. Start from what consumers need and build a product suite.” That in a nutshell is Kotak’s advice to the new hires. But this shift comes with some challenges. For instance, the bank’s employee turnover surged to 45 per cent in FY23 from 39 per cent in FY22, with the bank citing junior-level exits in sales, call centres and collections as the primary cause.

TWO-IN-A-BOX STRATEGY

Currently, banks are categorised by product or loan verticals. But the customer experiences the bank hori-

A Storied Legacy

UDAY KOTAK LEAVES BEHIND A RICH LEGACY AT THE ORGANISATION HE FOUNDED, WHICH SEEMS SET TO STAND THE TEST OF TIME

WHEN HENRY FORD made cheap, reliable cars, people said, ‘Nah, what’s wrong with a horse?’ That was a huge bet he made, and it worked,” Elon Musk, the owner of

Tesla, SpaceX, and X, recently said. Ford took a significant risk at the start of the 20th century, and it paid off. Uday Kotak (pictured), who coincidentally had a car financing joint venture with the US car-maker’s financial arm in his initial years, too took risks and successfully challenged established industry leaders to achieve significant success.

In its nearly four-decade journey, the Kotak Group has amassed total assets of ₹6.2 lakh crore, market capitalisation of over ₹3.5 lakh crore and employee strength of nearly 100,000. Kotak’s family was into cotton trading, but he started his journey with a bill-discounting business. Step by step, he built a financial powerhouse with a presence in banking, mutual funds, insurance, stock broking,

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Starts his entrepreneurial journey with bill discounting